

Run of Show

A 40-minute simulation in which students play the thirteen states of 1786, discover that a government designed to be weak cannot do anything, and argue about it.

What students actually learn

Most versions of this activity have students vote on resolutions and score them on the outcome. That teaches "the states disagreed," which they already suspect. This one is built around the thing that actually killed the Articles:

Passing a law and something happening are different events

After a money resolution passes, every delegation privately decides whether to *actually pay*. Nobody can make them — there is no president to collect and no court to sue. The projector then shows the gap. Your class will vote to raise \$1,000,000 and collect somewhere around \$300,000.

Between 1781 and 1786 the real Congress asked the states for about \$15 million and received about \$2.5 million. Roughly one dollar in six.

Scoring sets two numbers against each other. **State Interest** is private and rewards looking after yourself — refusing to pay is worth points. **National Stability** is shared and falls when Congress cannot act. The highest State Interest wins, *unless* National Stability drops below 30, at which point every state loses twenty points including the leader.

So the class plays correctly and loses collectively. That is the argument for the Constitution, and they make it themselves rather than hearing you make it.

Before the bell

- ☐ **Print the worksheet** — two pages, front and back, one per group. Keep the answer key for yourself.
- ☐ **Open the teacher page** on the projector machine. Name the session (for example "Period 3") and create it. You get a four-letter code.
- ☐ **Write the code on the board.** Big. You will be asked for it eleven times.
- ☐ **Choose your student states.** Six groups is the sweet spot. The recommended six are pre-selected.
- ☐ **Leave Rhode Island unchecked.** Round 3 needs a state to block the amendment, and a bot does it without a student taking the blame.
- ☐ **Put students in pairs**, one laptop each pair, and give them the student link.

Anything nobody claims is played by a bot, so a class of ten and a class of thirty both work. You can start before every group has joined.

The run of show

0-5 min

SETUP

Get them in and reading

Groups join with the code and claim a state. As they land, they get a short tour of their own screen automatically.

Read the framing paragraph on your lobby screen while they settle.

SAY

Three rules. One: every state gets one vote, whether you are Virginia with 700,000 people or Delaware with 59,000. Two: nine of thirteen have to agree to pass anything. Three: there is no president and there are no courts. Nobody can make any state do anything.

5-7 min

OPEN

Read the opening aloud

Begin Resolution 1 Each round opens with a short scene, about 45 seconds. It appears on your screen in large type and on every student screen at the same time. **Bigger text** is there if the back row needs it.

Read it properly. It is written to be performed, and it sets the tone for everything after.

SAY

The letter from Paris came this morning. It is extremely polite, and it is a threat.

7-9 min

DEBATE

Two minutes of chaos

Open debate Get them out of their seats. The timer runs on your screen and theirs.

Watch the **deal ticker** in your sidebar. When a good offer lands, read it out. Nothing makes the room louder than hearing "Virginia offers Delaware fifty thousand dollars."

Bots answer offers instantly. Student-run states have to be argued with in person — the app will not answer for them.

9-10 min

VOTE

Call the vote

Close debate — open voting Silence. Every delegation votes. Your sidebar shows who still hasn't.

Remind them abstaining is not neutral: nine yes votes are needed, so abstaining helps a resolution fail.

10-12 min

REVEAL

The roll call

Close voting — show result

The map lights up state by state, north to south, with the count climbing toward nine. Let it play. Do not talk over it.

If it passes, **do not celebrate**. Ask what happens next.

12-14 min

THE POINT

Now ask them to pay

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Each group decides privately whether to send the money. Then

Reveal who actually paid .

The same map runs again and goes dark red. The tally bar still says PASSED while a counter shows the money stalling far short.

SAY

Read the two numbers slowly. "Congress asked for one million dollars. Congress received three hundred thousand." Then stop talking and let them look at it.

Then read the "What actually happened" box aloud, and have them fill in the round box on their worksheet.

14-34 min

REPEAT

Rounds 2, 3 and 4

Same shape, about six minutes each. Rounds 2 and 3 have no payment step, so they run faster.

Keep the pace up. The simulation is better slightly rushed than dragged.

34-40 min

DEBRIEF

The turn

Show the debrief

Final standings, the totals, and the six weaknesses they just lived through — plus what the Articles actually got right.

Discussion questions are on your screen. Students finish page two of the worksheet.

The four resolutions

ROUND	WHAT IT EXPOSES	WHAT WILL PROBABLY HAPPEN
1. Paying the War Debt \$1,000,000 · 9 of 13	Congress could not tax. It could only ask.	Usually passes. Then roughly a third of the money arrives. This is the round that does the teaching.
2. The Trade War 9 of 13	Congress could not regulate trade between states.	Often passes — and changes nothing, because it is only a request. Ask them how it feels to win a vote that does nothing.
3. The Import Tax Amendment ALL 13	Amending the Articles needed every state.	It will fail. Rhode Island refuses. Expect real anger — that is the round working.
4. Shays' Rebellion \$500,000 · 9 of 13	No army, no president, and an empty treasury.	The opening reads out your class's real treasury balance. If they defected in Round 1, they hear their own number as the rebels march.

Round 3 is supposed to fail

Students will work the room hard and lose to one stubborn state. When they complain that it is rigged, tell them the truth: this was tried twice in real life. In 1782 twelve states approved the import tax and **Rhode Island alone** rejected it. In 1786 it was tried again and **New York alone** rejected it. One state in thirteen was enough, both times.

It is technically winnable — Rhode Island can be bought at an absurd price — so it is a wall they can push on, not one they cannot see.

Three moments to slow down for

The first payment reveal

The map goes red while the bar still says PASSED. Say nothing for five seconds. Then ask: "You voted for this. What happened?"

Rhode Island blocking the amendment

Click Rhode Island on the map to show its stated reason. Ask whether one state out of thirteen should be able to do that.

The final standings

If stability collapsed, everyone lost twenty points — including whoever finished first. Ask the leader what they did that worked, then whether any of it was good for the country.

And one thing not to skip

The debrief section on what the Articles *got right*. A unit that only shows failure teaches a cartoon.

If something goes wrong

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
A group can't join	Check the code. If their laptop is dead, they can share with another group, or you can vote on their behalf — every state is clickable on your List view.
A group joined late	Any unclaimed state is already a bot. Have them claim any state showing as open; if they need a specific one, they can take it back even if it shows as held.
A money resolution gets voted down	Use Congress tries again in the sidebar. It pushes the class to the payment step, which is where the lesson lives. Historically fair — Congress re-introduced failed requisitions year after year.
You're running out of time	Skip to the vote shortens debate. Cutting Round 2 costs you the least.
The WiFi dies	Keep the solo file on a flash drive. It needs no network at all and runs the whole simulation against bots.
You want to break quorum on purpose	Send 3 delegations home drops the room below nine states so no vote can be held. Congress genuinely could not meet for long stretches. Use it once, for effect.

Running it over two days

It saves as it goes — every vote, payment and score is stored the moment it happens, so stopping is just stopping. There is no save button because there is nothing to save.

When the bell goes, press **Stop here — continue another day**. It shows the session name, the code in large type, and where you stopped, so you can photograph it. Next day, open the teacher page and either type that code into **Resume that session** or pick the class out of **Recent sessions**. Everything comes back — states, scores, treasury, voting history — and you can resume on a different computer.

Where to break: after the reveal of Resolution 2. Day two then opens on the import tax amendment, which needs the most argument and lands hardest when they have had a night to stew about Rhode Island. Tell groups on day one to write down which state they are.

Assessment

During

Worksheet page one, one box per round. Circling and two lines of writing — it should not compete with the game for their attention.

After

Worksheet page two: the six weaknesses, what the Articles got right, the totals, and two reflection questions. Answer key toggles on in the worksheet file.

Exit ticket

One sentence: name a weakness you felt today and say how the Constitution fixed it.

The question worth grading

"Your state scored well by refusing to pay. So why did the country end up worse off?" That is the whole unit in one answer.

What is real and what is compressed

Real: the nine-of-thirteen rule and the thirteen-state amendment rule; one vote per state regardless of size; requisitions as requests states routinely ignored; New York taxing goods bound for New Jersey and Connecticut, and New Jersey taxing New York's lighthouse at Sandy Hook; Rhode Island blocking the impost in 1782 and New York in 1786; Shays leading about 1,200 men against the Springfield arsenal on 25 January 1787, four farmers killed, the rebellion ended by a private army of 4,000 paid for by Boston merchants; Britain holding its frontier forts over unpaid debts; Spain closing the Mississippi.

Compressed: four resolutions stand in for years of congressional business, and they are placed in one dramatic arc rather than strict chronological order. State treasuries are simplified round numbers. Bot personalities are drawn from each state's real interests but they are models, not transcripts.

Worth saying out loud: the western land the Northwest Ordinance organised so neatly was not empty. It was home to the Shawnee, Miami, Delaware and many other nations, none of whom agreed to any of it.